Hardware & Networking

Cloud Capex Wrap-Up: Meta Joins SpaceX in Reinforcing AI Infrastructure Demand with Capex Raise in C3Q26

IT Hardware/ Telecom & Networking Equipment

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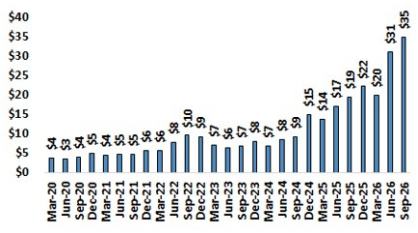
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Meta was the first of the four major U.S. hyperscalers to report C3Q26 results, which in our view joined SpaceX (see report here) in supporting continued momentum for AI infrastructure spend and cuts against recent concerns about whether the investment cycle is sustainable. Meta raised its full-year 2026 capex outlook at the midpoint, implying growth of +94% y/y (*+$68 bn y/y*) and a substantial sequential acceleration in capex growth for C4Q (*+55% q/q vs. +12% q/q in C3Q*26). Looking forward, Meta underscored its intention to "continue investing aggressively" next year to support both the core business and new AI initiatives. For example, compute was highlighted as a key constraint on scaling MUSE, which passed 10 mn setups in the U.S. and Canada in about six weeks, with Meta building capacity to serve more than a billion people over the next few years, while also noting the buildout of Meta Enterprise Platform (*model API, MUSE Code, and business agents*) to capture high-margin inference demand. Importantly, management stressed that its AI investments in the core business are already bringing in substantial incremental advertising revenue and supporting revenue growth of +26% y/y in C3Q26 and guidance for growth of +22-27% y/y in C4Q26. To that end, we see Meta's results as further evidence of the sustainability around AI data center investments and supporting a favorable backdrop for the companies in our coverage with leverage to AI infrastructure spending.

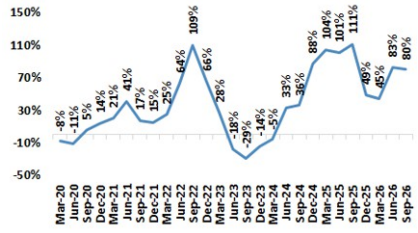
- **Meta (covered by Doug Anmuth): Raises full-year 2026 capex outlook at midpoint; signals continued aggressive investment in 2027.** C3Q26 capex rose +12% q/q and +80% y/y to $35 bn, bringing YTD capex to $86 bn (*+71% y/y),* and driven by servers, data centers, and network infrastructure. Looking ahead, Meta raised its 2026 capex guidance to $135-145 bn (*vs. $130-145 bn in C2Q and $125-145 bn in C1Q)*, implying growth of +88-101% y/y or a dollar increase of +$63-73 bn. The guide also suggests C4Q26 capex of $49-59 bn (*+41-70% q/q; +122-167% y/y*), which represents a steep sequential acceleration in capex growth into the end of the year. Looking forward, Meta underscored its intention to "continue investing aggressively" next year.

Figure 1: Quarterly Meta Capex
$ in Billions



Source: Company reports

Figure 2: Quarterly Meta Capex
Y/Y % Change



Source: Company reports

See page 2 for analyst certification and important disclosures.

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Completed 21 Oct 2026 08:36 PM EDT

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